Premier Zhu Rongji in private, in an anteroom, after the official talks. Premier Zhu heard Vajpayee out. As Premier Zhu was ascending in the elevator to return to his hotel suite after the official dinner hosted by Prime Minister Vajpayee, he told his colleagues of his conversation with the latter. Vajpayee, he said, had told him that the time had come to resolve the Sikkim Question. When a member of his entourage inquired as to what he had replied, Zhu said that he had told Vajpayee that he would consider the matter, whereupon Vajpayee had pressed the request. Premier Zhu asked the accompanying officials to study the matter upon their return to Beijing. Knowledge of this conversation came to light because a young, and exceptionally alert, officer who was present in the elevator as a liaison officer to the Chinese delegation, and who spoke Chinese fluently, promptly reported it to his superiors. [17] It is in this manner that the Indian side learned that the matter would be looked at afresh in Beijing after the Chinese Premier's return. This had been the objective of Prime Minister Vajpayee and his government.

In the summer of 2002, External Affairs Minister Jaswant Singh travelled to China for his second visit. He had developed a good equation with his counterpart, Foreign Minister Tang Jiaxuan. In his book, Jaswant Singh recalled that during this visit he had tentatively raised the question of Chinese recognition of Sikkim as a part of India with Tang Jiaxuan, and that it 'eventually resulted in the assurance that during the next visit of the Chinese Premier such an announcement would be made.' [18] Jaswant Singh had actually got the sequence a little mixed up. Jaswant Singh's very first meeting in Beijing was with Vice Premier Qian Qichen, who was the Politburo member responsible for overseeing China's foreign relations. [19]

Qian had come straight to the point on Sikkim, and suggested that border trade might be resumed immediately through